

Expenses can be as crippling. DR-TB treatment can take up to two years, compared to six months for regular TB. And over that period, according to the Pretoria-headquartered Global TB Alliance for TB Drug Development, a patient needs around 14,000 pills—roughly 20 pills a day. Costs for treatment can vary from Rs 1.3 lakh to Rs 25 lakh for two years, according to a 2019 study of 50 DR-TB patients at Hinduja Hospital in Mumbai published in PubMed. The 2022 India TB report, too, states that 68 per cent of DR-TB patients in India find the treatment cost catastrophic. In comparison, patients currently on treatment for standard TB need to spend a total of Rs 7,500 in the public sector and Rs 20,000 in the private sector, including indirect costs, according to the NATBPS or the National TB Prevalence Survey, 2019-2021.

WINNING THE WAR

The Indian government remains determined to eliminate all forms of TB by 2025 and believes it is well on its way to achieving the target. Kerala and Karnataka reduced cases by nearly 40 per cent between 2015 and 2021, according to Union health ministry figures. In fact, Lakshadweep and Budgam district in Jammu and Kashmir were declared TB-free in 2021, and overall, J&K has reduced cases by 20 per cent. In Maharashtra, one of the worst affected TB states, the Ahmednagar district has achieved 60 per cent reduction, while Akola and Beed have seen cases dropping by 20 per cent. The government attributes these successes to the series of schemes it has put in motion.



"WE ARE ENGAGING WITH PEOPLE TO **IMPROVE AWARENESS ABOUT TB SYMPTOMS**, AND ARE FINDING OUT MORE ABOUT THE OUTCOMES OF OUR TB TREATMENTS"

–NARESH TREHAN
Chairman, Medanta – The Medicity, Gurugram

In September last year, President Droupadi Murmu launched the Pradhan Mantri TB-Mukt Bharat Abhiyan (PMTBMBA), which allows ministers, celebrities, businessmen, corporates and NGOs to adopt TB patients and become 'Ni-kshay Mitras'. Not only does it help mobilise financial resources, but it also bridges the gap between society and the lonely world of the TB patient, becoming a source for emotional support and easing of stigma. Currently, the government claims nearly 75,000 people and organisations are part of the scheme and 1.01 million patients have been adopted. The programme, says, Union health minister Mansukh Mandaviya, "is a call to action



ASHNA ASHESH
30, Lawyer, Patna

OF MIND AND BODY

Even though Ashna, who was diagnosed with MDR-TB in 2017, had family and friends to support her, the disease plunged her into depression. She learnt how rarely the mental health effects of TB were spoken about. Doctors dismissed it, families couldn't comprehend it. "I realised depression takes just as much of a toll on the patient as the physical illness. Unsurprisingly, TB patients often face difficulty in complying with TB treatment," she says. Cured now, Ashna is working to support people with TB-related mental health issues. "Without a comprehensive plan that includes free counselling, TB patients in India are left to their own devices," she says.